

THE SPICE ROUTE

One of India's most evocative food writers takes a trip through the culinary traditions of the country



EATING INDIA: AN ODYSSEY INTO THE FOOD AND CULTURE OF THE LAND OF SPICES
by CHITRITA BANERJI
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■ By Nilanjana S. Roy

Nine years before Jhumpa Lahiri combined the flavours of nostalgia and assimilation in a strange land with evocative descriptions of food from 'home' in *Interpreter of Maladies*, Chitrata Banerji had laid claim to similar territory. In her classic food memoir *Life and Food in Bengal*, she untangled the taboos and rituals of the kitchen, combining the deep knowledge of the insider with the clear, sharp vision of the outsider. Over the years, writing for magazines from *Gourmet* to *Granta*, Banerji has become one of the most evocative of Indian food writers, blending an exact understanding of techniques with an abiding curiosity about the many human stories behind the art of food. She was the perfect culinary pilgrim, delving into the mysteries of what the Bengali widow may or may not eat, interrogating the hidden meanings behind the wedding feasts, examining the real cost of having someone grind and prepare your 'fresh' spices for you. Her descriptions of *maacher jhol* or cunningly spiced vegetable stews were well-written enough to have readers salivating.

Eating India is conceived on a grand scale: this is nothing less, the subtitle informs us, than *An Odyssey into the Food and Culture of the Land of Spices*. Between 2003 and 2006, Banerji made several trips to India, travelling to Gujarat, Goa, Bengal, Bangalore, seeking out *langar* food in the gurdwaras of Amritsar, searching for the

lost Seder of the dwindling Jewish-Indian community. This edition is clearly intended for "American diners" who usually encounter dishes that "have their origins in just one region, Punjab", as a way of broadening their culinary ideas of India, and has been laid out, as a note to the reader puts it, "for the convenience of readers who have not been to India". It would be a rare Indian, though, who can resist Banerji's enthusiasm for her subject, or who would not enjoy her descriptions of the "new" highway food—greasy Chinese noodles instead of *sattu*. "Ersatz Chinese food," she observes with some disapproval, "has become the *khichuri* of the new millennium."

In marked contrast to most of her previous work, Banerji is not a pilgrim here, nor a seasoned traveller down these culinary trails. After the chapter on Bengali food, which reprises in a slightly different key her memories of

the peculiarities of a palate that loves bitter vegetables and sweet desserts with equal fervour, Banerji must move into less familiar territory. She finds contentment eating among friendly strangers in the *langars* of Amritsar; contrasts the rich, nawabi cuisine of Lucknow with the *kacchi biryani* of Hyderabad. She samples the *thandai* and *jalebis* rather than the austere widow's cuisine of Benaras, and travels via the *appams* and *thorans* of Kerala into the intricacies of the Syrian Christian kitchen, the vanishing secrets of *aloo makallah* and Jewish food.

Eating India, despite the neatly packaged snippets of Indian history and the abundance of food descriptions, is disappointing. It lacks the informed passion of Banerji's best work, and her curiosity and professionalism, however infectious, are no replacement for the expertise and the deep and intense cultural understanding

she's brought to previous books. Too often, she leaves a place—Bombay, Bangalore, Ahmedabad—at the precise point where you're hoping she will explore further and come up with a trademark insight, the odd astonishing anecdote. This does happen in *Eating India*, but not nearly often enough.

But many readers in India and elsewhere are too cautious to sample the *thali* at the next table, the contents of their neighbour's tiffin-carrier, the secret delights of an unfamiliar but related cuisine. *Eating India* might persuade the classic conservative Indian—one who would order tandoori chicken in a Michelin restaurant or a Kerala home-style kitchen—or the classic conservative Westerner who wouldn't dream of moving beyond vindaloo or chicken tikka masala, that there's life beyond the fixed menu. ■

